What Depot Does

Let's start by jotting down an outline specification for the Depot application. We'll look at the high-level use cases and sketch out the flow through the web pages. We'll also try working out what data the application needs (acknowledging that our initial guesses will likely be wrong).

Use Cases

A *use case* is simply a statement about how some entity uses a system. Consultants invent these kinds of phrases to label things we've known all along. (It's a perversion of business life that fancy words always cost more than plain ones, even though the plain ones are more valuable.)

Depot's use cases are simple (some would say tragically so). We start off by identifying two different roles or actors: the *buyer* and the *seller*.

The buyer uses Depot to browse the products we have to sell, select some to purchase, and supply the information needed to create an order.

The seller uses Depot to maintain a list of products to sell, to determine the orders that are awaiting shipment, and to mark orders as shipped. (The seller also uses Depot to make scads of money and retire to a tropical island, but that's the subject of another book.)

For now, that's all the detail we need. We *could* go into excruciating detail about what it means to maintain products and what constitutes an order ready to ship, but why bother? If some details aren't obvious, we'll discover them soon enough as we reveal successive iterations of our work to the customer.

Speaking of getting feedback, let's get some right now. Let's make sure our initial (admittedly sketchy) use cases are on the mark by asking our users. Assuming the use cases pass muster, let's work out how the application will work from the perspectives of its various users.